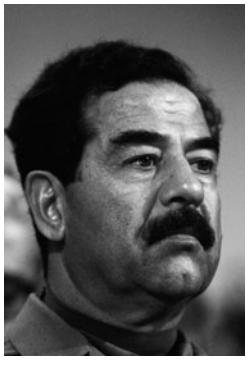

Profile: Saddam Hussein 1937–2006

1937	–	Born into a poor peasant family in Takrit, near Baghdad
1957	–	Became a Baath Party activist
1963	–	Became head of the Iraqi Intelligence Services
1968–79	–	Vice-President of Iraq
1979	–	Became President of Iraq
1980–8	–	War with Iran
1990	–	Invasion of Kuwait
1991	–	Iraq defeated by US-led coalition and UN sanctions imposed
2003	–	US-led invasion led to end of Saddam's regime and later capture
2004–6	–	Trial and execution for crimes against humanity

Saddam was brought up by his uncle and, as a young man, was immersed in the anti-British, anti-Western atmosphere of the Arab world in the late 1950s and the 1960s. He was involved in the overthrow of the pro-British monarchy in 1958. In the 1960s and 1970s, he emerged as the strong man of the Iraqi regime, establishing control over the security services and, later, the army. He oversaw the nationalisation of Iraq's oil industry in 1972 and used Iraq's oil wealth to build up education, health and welfare services that were among the best in the Arab world.

As President, Saddam was ruthless in eliminating his rivals and, like Stalin whom he admired, he used 'show trials' of his enemies to enforce submission to his rule. Many of his closest advisers came from the same Takrit clan as he did and several members of his close family, including his two sons, held important posts in government.

Saddam's eight-year war with Iran, which ended in 1988, led to stalemate, huge debt and a shattered economy. Yet two years later, his army invaded Kuwait, claiming that the country belonged to Iraq. Defeat by US-led forces and the imposition of UN sanctions were to weaken Iraq and bring misery to the people, yet Saddam remained defiant. His propaganda machine portrayed him as the father-figure and protector of his people while he continued to have his opponents, including two sons-in-law, murdered.

In 2003, the USA and its allies launched an invasion, claiming that Iraq still had WMD, and overthrew Saddam's regime. Saddam escaped and went into hiding but was captured by US troops in December 2003. After a two-year trial he was sentenced, by an Iraqi court, to death by hanging, a sentence that was carried out in December 2006.